

Guide for the Grown-Up

New here? This is everything you need. Read it once and you will be ready for any kit in the library. It takes a few minutes.

What this is

If you have never played a game like this, picture a bedtime story that your child helps to steer, a little like a choose-your-own-adventure book acted out loud together. That is really all it is. This is a cooperative story-and-puzzle adventure you play with a child, or a few children, out loud, with a printed kit and a few household bits. There is no app and no screen. You read a little story, the children make choices, and together you solve gentle puzzles with simple dice. You are all on the same side, helping each other through, never playing against one another. It is a way to practise imagination, problem-solving, and working together, and a lovely excuse for unhurried, screen-free time, which researchers link to how well children settle and thrive. You need no experience at all. If you can read a bedtime story, you can run this.

What playing actually looks like

Here is a whole turn, so you can picture it. You read a line, a child answers, and a roll of the die adds a pinch of surprise:

- **You read:** "The vine gate is knotted shut. What do you do?"
- **A child:** "I ask my owl to peck it open."
- **You:** "Lovely idea. That is a Normal challenge, so give the die a roll." They roll a three. "The owl tugs hard and one knot springs loose. One more good idea and you are through."

That is the whole engine: a question, an idea, a roll, and a "yes, and" that keeps the story moving. No one can fail their way out of the fun; a low roll just means you find another way. The story tells you when to roll, the Playbook gives you the answers, and this Guide does the rest.

Worlds, stories, and kits

The library is built from **worlds**, **stories**, and the **kits** you print.

- A **world** is a setting with its own places, characters, and look: a cluster of floating islands, the sunlit hills of Greek myth, the snowlit fjords of the north, and more, with new worlds added over time.
- A **story** is one self-contained adventure inside a world, with its own path of stops and its own puzzles. A world holds several stories, and you can play them in any order.
- A **kit** is everything you need to play one story. You pick a world, pick a story, and print that kit. Each story comes at a reading level to suit your children's age, and in more than one language.

You never need to read a whole world to begin. One story is one evening.

What is in a kit, and what to print

A kit arrives as a few short PDFs. You do not have to print them all.

- **The Story Pack.** This is the one to **print**. It is the child-safe booklet you play from: the opening, a map, the story to read aloud, the pictures, and a blank **adventure sheet** on the last page.

- **The Grown-up's Playbook.** The rules and, crucially, the **answers** to the puzzles. This part is for you, not for the children. You can keep it on a phone or a screen to save paper. **Read it before you start.**
- **The World Book** (optional). A "who's who" of the world's characters and creatures, plus a bank of extra ideas, for when you want more. Nice to have, never needed.
- **Example heroes** (optional). A page of ready-made heroes, already filled in, to show your children what a hero can look like. Print it for inspiration, or just glance at it on screen.
- **This Guide** (read once). What you are reading now. After this you are set for every kit in the library.

The shortest path: print the **Story Pack**, keep the **Playbook** open beside you, and go.

The adventure sheet

The last page of every Story Pack is an **adventure sheet**, where each player makes their own hero. Everyone takes one, you included. A player writes a name, gives their hero three **magics** (or, in worlds without magic, three **strengths** such as wits, courage, or a kind heart), draws a quick picture, and lists the few things they carry. The five **energy stars** are coloured in as they are spent during play, so print a fresh sheet for each player and each new adventure. The **example heroes** show what a finished one looks like. Making a hero takes a couple of minutes and is part of the fun, so do not skip it.

Before you begin: a five-minute setup

1. **Read the Playbook** once, and skim the story so you know its shape. You do not need to memorise anything; the pages prompt you as you go. 2. **Print** the Story Pack, plus a spare adventure sheet for each player. 3. **Gather** a single six-sided die (one is enough for any kit), a pencil each, and a small handful of tokens, coins, or buttons to stand in for the players and to mark the energy stars. 4. **Settle** somewhere comfortable, with no screens and no rush.

That is all the preparation a kit ever needs.

Your jobs, and you get to play too

You are the **Game Master**, which is just a few small jobs at once. You are also a fellow adventurer at the table, not a referee standing apart: you play on the children's side, helping them find the way.

- **The narrator.** Read the story parts aloud, warmly. Do a silly voice if you fancy it. Pause at the questions and let the children answer.
- **The gentle referee.** When the players try something, you decide how it goes, always leaning towards yes. The puzzle pages give you the answers, so you are never caught out.
- **The biggest fan.** Cheer every idea, especially the odd ones. Your delight is the engine of the whole game.
- **A fellow adventurer.** Take a hero of your own and play along. You have read ahead, but you do not have to act like it: let yourself be surprised, wonder out loud, and discover each turn with the children. Helping them through is the whole point, not being the one who knows.

Introducing it to the children

Open with the promise, build a hero each, then begin.

- **Make the promise first.** Tell them the one rule before anything else: "In this game nobody loses. We are all on the same side, and if something does not work, we just find another way." That single sentence frees a child to be bold.

- **Build a hero each.** Hand out the adventure sheets and make your heroes together, you included. Let them pick a name and three magics or strengths, and draw their picture. The example heroes are there if anyone wants a model.
- **Set the scene.** Read the opening of the story aloud, slowly, and ask the first question. From there the story carries you both along.

Then play on, following the rest of this Guide. You are all adventurers now.

The one golden rule: yes, and

Whatever your child suggests, try to say "**yes, and...**" rather than "no". If they want to befriend the monster, talk to the river, or fly on a borrowed cloud, let them, and add a little twist that keeps the story moving. "Yes, the vines pull back, and as they do you spot something glinting underneath." Saying yes keeps a child leaning in. Saying no, again and again, is the one sure way to lose them.

Nobody loses, ever

This is the heart of every kit: **a failed roll is never a defeat, only a detour.** If a dice roll comes up short, do not stop the story. The players can spend an energy star and try again, combine their strengths, accept a helpful nudge from a friendly creature, or simply find another way round. Treat a miss as a funny surprise, not a failure. No child is ever knocked out, left behind, or made to feel they have let the team down.

When they get stuck

Sticking is normal. Reach for these, in order:

- Offer a **friendly hint** through a character ("the cat nudges a loose vine...").
- **Lower the difficulty** one band, or let the helper roll carry it.
- Let them **combine their strengths** for an automatic success.
- If all else stalls, **just let them succeed.** Momentum matters more than rigour. A child who feels clever will play for an hour; a child who feels stuck will wander off.

Keeping a young child captivated

- Do **voices** for the characters; it is half the magic.
- **Hand them the dice** and let them roll. Holding the dice is holding the story.
- Offer **choices** ("do you knock, or do you peek?") rather than open silence.
- Keep scenes **short** and end on a small win.
- **Follow their excitement.** If they love the talking fountain, linger there.
- **Take breaks.** A kit is happy to be played across several sittings.

Silly or impossible answers

These are a gift, not a problem. If your child says the door opens because "a dragon eats it", grin and run with it: "the dragon gulps the gate down, burps, and trots off, and now the way is clear." If an idea truly cannot work, let the world answer kindly: "the rock is too heavy to lift, but look, there is a gap you could wriggle through." Never just block them; always offer a door.

Pacing and length

Aim for fifteen to thirty minutes at a sitting, less for little ones. You may **skip a puzzle**, shorten the reading, or **stop early** and pick up next time. There is no clock and no score. The best ending is a child asking to play again.

A handful of ready phrases

Keep these on the tip of your tongue:

- "Yes, and..."
- "Ooh, what a clever idea. What happens next?"
- "You can absolutely try that. Let us see..."
- "That did not quite work, so what else could we do?"
- "You did that by being clever and kind. Well done."

Wits and Wonder

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<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.